Ajmer, as usual, before heading east, Akbar ordered that any farmers whose crops were damaged by the marching of his troops be indemnified. This would become ‘a rule in all [Akbar’s] campaigns’, writes Nizamuddin, with imperial inspectors sometimes heading into the fields with ‘bags of money’ to settle any claims as they arose, and thus ‘obviate any interference with the revenue collections’.

Keeping farmers happy was important.[20] If Akbar wanted agriculture to thrive, to bring more and more land under cultivation, he would have to ensure the contentment of his cultivators – but that, alone, wasn’t enough. Much of Akbar’s empire was held in fief, after all, by various chiefs of varying honesty. These fief-holders were responsible for collecting and remitting taxes to the centre, but they did so – *if* they did so – on the basis of outdated land records and inaccurate assessments of their worth. One of the great projects of Akbar’s rule, therefore, was an extensive reassessment of cultivated land.

This was easier said than done – fief-holders would hardly appreciate or encourage reassessments that increased their tax obligations to the imperial treasury. It was to deal with such resistance that Akbar began to toy with the idea of turning all his realm into imperial ‘*khalsa*’ land – to be administered by the crown, that is – and of turning his revenue-collecting fief-holders into salaried officers, ‘*mansabdars*’.

Bureaucracies were creeping upon the world. The Chinese already had an entrance exam for their administrators.[21] In both Central Asia and Hindustan, meanwhile, a slow but certain shift in ‘political structure’ had been ongoing for some time, as a modern historian argues, its command moving from ‘aristocratic lineages to . . . kings and men of lesser social standing who had been “trained” by the monarch’. A time was coming, that is, when it was not so much a man’s noble ancestry, ‘*asl va nasab*’, that gave him worth or power, but rather his education and training, his ‘*tarbiyat*’.[22]

Perhaps this explains why Akbar sat and scrutinized the opinions and intelligence of men like Badauni and Abul Fazl with such a close eye – not only because they were seeking their fortunes in his court, but equally because he sought a future for his realm in their talents.

But first, he sought Bihar and Bengal.